Dungeons & Gardens

The salt spray stings your faces as the longship grinds against the icy pier of Palebank Village. The groan of splintering ice mixes with the cries of gulls and the shouts of dockworkers bundled in furs. Palebank Villages greets you with a blast of frigid air, a stark contrast to the relative warmth of the southern seas you've left behind. The sky above is a perpetual grey, heavy with the promise of more snow.

You've endured weeks at sea, braving treacherous currents and icy squalls aboard the *Frostwind*, a sturdy, if somewhat cramped, longship captained by the weathered and taciturn Jarl Stonebeard. The journey itself proved more than just a test of sea legs; it was during those long, monotonous days and nights that your paths first crossed. Over shared meals of salted fish and hardtack, huddled around the meager warmth of the ship's brazier, you discovered a shared purpose beneath your disparate backgrounds. Perhaps it was a whispered conversation overheard in the galley, a chance encounter on deck under the pale moonlight, or a late-night debate in the cramped crew quarters, but you each realized you were drawn north by the same alluring whispers: the rediscovery of Aeorian ruins, remnants of a lost civilization swallowed by the Frostfell. Tales of lost cities and powerful artifacts have spread like wildfire, carried on the winds and traded in taverns from the Menagerie Coast to the shores of Wildemount. These stories have lured explorers, scholars, and fortune-seekers alike to this desolate land, and fate, or perhaps something more, has brought you together on this shared voyage.

Palebank Village, a ramshackle collection of wooden buildings huddled against the harsh landscape, serves as the primary gateway to the frozen Island of Eiselcross to the North. Here, amidst the bustle of fur traders, fisherfolk, grizzled explorers, shady mercenaries and hopeful fortune-seekers, you disembark. The air is thick with anticipation, a palpable sense of excitement mixed with a healthy dose of apprehension. The promise of uncovering lost knowledge, powerful magic, and perhaps even unimaginable wealth hangs heavy in the air, a beacon in this frozen wilderness. But the frozen shores of Eiselcross hold many secrets, and the ruins of Aeor are guarded by more than just ice and snow. Ancient dangers stir beneath the frozen surface, and the secrets you seek may come at a terrible price. Your journey into the heart of Eiselcross begins now, the moment your boots touch the frozen ground.

Welcome to Palebank Village

In the frosty expanse of the colder reaches of Wildemount, in the Greying Wildlands south of the Islands of Eiselcross, lay the haphazard cluster known as Palebank Village. It was a place more cobbled together than planned, with just over a hundred cabins and shacks pressed against the northern cliffs that rose a mere fifteen feet against the lapping rhythms of the icy harbor waves. The docks, busy with the absence of departing ships, whispered tales of neglect and wariness.

On this frigid day, the village was subdued, gathered in mournful procession for the unfortunate Urgon, a dwarven adventurer whose final journey was to the graveyard west of the harbor. There, encased in a casket more suitable for a relic than a beloved friend, he lay suspended in a state of frozen eternity. Villagers whispered tales of his return from a year-long venture into Eiselcross, burdened with treasures and a chilling affliction. Despite countless efforts, Urgon could never find warmth. Eventually, blue streaks marred his pallor, snaking through his veins, until his entire being succumbed to the grip of frost.

We followed the procession, taking note of the landscape dotted with quaint inns and supply shops. Amongst the mourners stood a weathered elf adorned with the insignia of a "Glassblade". Introducing himself as Elro, he shared that the usual voyages to Aeor had ceased; a silent testament to the mystery shrouding Urgon's demise. Elro sought our help in unveiling the source of this insidious curse, admitting that Urgon's home remained unexplored.

Word reached us quickly that another villager named Tulgi was showing similar symptoms—her fate seemingly entwined with Urgon's. Fortuitously, their cabins stood in proximity.

Beer with the Locals

In the heart of the village, a jovial dwarf Bortock tended bar at the local tavern. Elara, ever inquisitive, engaged Bortock in conversation about Urgon's recent exploits. A night's rest was negotiated—two rooms for eight silver pieces—before being served beer by the bucket and a meal of squid rolls.

Bill, a stalwart Glassblade at one of the tavern tables, emphasized that due to the danger of the curse, all boats were being warned off from Palebank's docks. Meanwhile, we learned Tulgi was a solitary trapper, her life a mystery to most.

The Cabins of Urgon and Tulgi

With this knowledge, we ventured to Urgon's cabin where another Glass Blade vigilantly stood post. Halite led us inside, where chaos had left its mark. The mounted head of a snowy beast with grey horns seemed to have overseen the search. Books were strewn about, gear tossed aside as if someone had been desperately seeking something. Scarlet's keen eyes caught sight of a grappling hook, swiftly claiming it. Meanwhile, with a sharp mind for details, Halite, discovered a receipt within a book. Dated two months prior, it recorded the sale of Aeorian items at the local Pelc's Curiosities for a handsome sum of one thousand gold pieces. Among the items: a dagger, a scroll case, a jade statue, a quiver of arrows, a jasper-set silver ring, and two blue glass vials.

Our eyes traced tracks leading to Tulgi Lutan's snow-burdened cabin. The warmth of a fierce fire belied the untouched exterior and shuttered windows. Scarlet's knock brought a curt response, followed by Elara's soft

words which coaxed the door open. Tulgi's face, marked by the same blue streaks that had doomed Urgon, was a testament to her shared affliction. She admitted her illness, confessing she and her sister Hulil, newcomers from Shady Creek Run, were in league with a crime syndicate. They had been sent to pilfer Aeorian treasures. It was they who had ransacked Urgon's home, and Tulgi who now surrendered a finely wrought dagger into Kragor's keeping.

She said that her sister Hulil held the remainder of the treasures in Croaker Cave, though Tulgi hadn't seen her in weeks.

Onward

With our next destination clear, we hiked to Pelc's Curiosities. We found the shop marked by a dragon-gilded "P" where the front door sagged invitingly open, beckoning us into the next chapter of this unfolding tale.

Pelc's Curiosities

The party stands outside Pelc's Curiosities, the door slightly ajar. Suspecting intruders, Whisper closes her eyes while softly purring "Maior et Fortior". The air around her shimmers momentarily as she draws on her inner ki in concentration. She then peers into the doors and the windows of the building. Despite her efforts, she cannot make out very much, though she hears enough rustling to make her hairs bristle. It sounds as though there are several inside ransacking the place. Scarlet joins Whisper's investigation, attempting to divine whether the noises might simply be animals, yet she senses no wildlife inside.

Preparing for potential conflict, Kragor stands up straight and stretches out his arms as if to grasp a weapon. In a loud yet distant voice he exclaims "Malleum Evoco". Suddenly ethereal shadows stream in from all directions and coalesce into an obsidian black war hammer with an angular and brutal head. Its every surface is etched with subtle twisting runes. Kragor hefts the weapon with both hands, then widens his stance with feet planted firmly on the ground.

The goliath Halite likewise readies himself, his massive frame towering above even Kragor. With deliberate, practiced movements, he adjusts his gleaming bronze shield, its surface etched with intricate clan markings. In one enormous hand he carefully grips his trident, its three wickedly barbed prongs designed not just to pierce, but to tear and rend flesh. The trident promises not just death, but a savage, lingering demise.

Surprise

Inside Pelc's Curiosities lie the answers to the freezing curse. Anxious for action, Elara takes a deep breath, tapping into her well of magic. Her fingers trace the air, summoning the rhythm of a battle drum. Her magic ignites, sending an illusory racket echoing from within the shop's shadowed walls. Startled into silence, the adversaries within hold their breath, their schemes momentarily unraveled. As Whisper crouches beside her, he senses the tension mounting. Without warning, a crossbow bolt whistles past, narrowly missing him. Elara's calculated ruse works, urging their foes to react blindly. The door slams shut, a temporary barrier between them and danger.

"So much for the element of surprise," mutters Kragor.

Undeterred, Elara shoulders the door open again. Darkness seeped around her like ink in water, yet her keen eyes, accustomed to shadow, discerned the outlines of two startled bandits amid the cluttered ruins of the shop. Ancient relics lay strewn about like casualties of an invisible war; toppled bookshelves and shattered relics spoke of a hasty, chaotic search.

The bandits, their nerves frayed by Elara's eerie magic, released their crossbow bolts in a jittery frenzy. The bolts missed their marks, striking harmlessly against worn brick and aged wood. Assessing the chaotic tableau before her, Elara hesitated; caution whispered in her ear, suggesting a withdrawal from direct assault into strategic retreat.

Inspiration and Fog

She retreated to her waiting comrades, her mind spinning a fresh tapestry of strategy. Checking again her surroundings, Kragor meets her gaze with a blend of curiosity and gruff admiration. Her eyes locked with his, and in that silent exchange, understanding was born. Elara struck her hand drum, each beat a pulse of power transmitted through the air, wrapping around Kragor like a cloak of inspiration. The rhythmic symphony reignited his focus, sharpening his spirit for the clash ahead.

But as this is happening, Scarlet quickly reacts. "Voco Nubes!" she bellows while raising her gnarled staff to the sky. Her eyes close in concentration as she summons nature's veil. Wisps of mist curl around her fingers before surging toward the building. The vapor seeps through cracks and under doorways, expanding rapidly into a dense, swirling fog that blankets the room. The once-clear space becomes an opaque, ethereal haze, obscuring vision and muffling sound. The druid smiles, knowing the shrouded interior will confound any occupants, granting her allies the advantage they seek within the murky cover of the fog cloud. She wastes no time taking advantage of it herself: she sneaks into the building and hugs the wall, moving to the right. She can hear others moving inside as well, but can make out nothing through the fog.

First Blood

Watching one of his allies attacked and another diving into the fog and what must certainly be mortal danger, Kragor strains to think. He feels like a sitting duck outside with obscured enemies inside, ready to make a pincushion out of him with their crossbow bolts. Taking a deep breath to overcome his fear, he too rushes through the doorway into the shrouding fog, gripping his massive conjured war hammer tightly. Unable to see, he positions himself protectively before where he believes Scarlet to be, straining to detect any threats hidden in the mist. A sudden noise to his left spurs him into action. He swings wildly, the war hammer arcing through the air, and feels a heavy impact followed by a muffled crunch. The enemy's body collapses to the ground with a lifeless thud.

The Roof

Outside, Whisper's sharp tabaxi senses are attuned to every movement around her. As her gaze sweeps upward, it catches upon an unexpected anomaly: a crouched form perched on the rooftop. Though the figure's features are obscured by distance, their posture is a tapestry of uncertainty, a riddle waiting to be unraveled. Without hesitation, Whisper draws upon her innate agility, launching herself up the building's facade, her movements a dance of precision and power. Within moments, she alights upon the roof beside the puzzled figure. As she closes in, a momentary clumsiness intrudes upon her fluid motion; her limbs entangle with the figure in a grapple that is awkward but surprisingly effective. Despite the ungraceful tangle of arms and legs, her determination holds fast, securing her quarry beneath the vast blue sky. The figure, now clearly a rogue based on their dark attire and tools of the trade hanging from their belt, desperately attempts to free themselves from Whisper's grasp, to no effect.

Counterattack

Halite now grasps the perilous choice the party has made in their recklessness. With a fierce resolve etched in the hard lines of his goliath visage, he charges through the fog-choked doorway, instinctively veering left to secure the flank opposite Scarlet and Kragor. The mist clings to him, a shroud of uncertainty, yet he moves with the confidence of one accustomed to the unseen. A bandit lunges at him, the attack a mere whisper of danger that dissolves into emptiness. Seizing the opportunity, Halite's fingers tighten around his trident, that harbinger of despair. With an expert thrust, the weapon slices through the fog, hungry for blood. It strikes true, embedding itself deep within the bandit with a sickening resistance, as though the weapon savored its work. Halite has to struggle to wrench it free from the bandit with raw power, the action accompanied by a dreadful noise that the fog quickly absorbs.

While recovering his favored weapon, Halite hears the "whoosh" of a crossbow bolt. He flinches, but he is not the target. He hears Kragor cry out in desperate pain.

The bolt had struck Kragor just below the collarbone, close to his heart. Blood flows unchecked, staining his leather armor.

Seconds later, another bolt pierces Scarlet and a sharp pain flares beneath her ribs. Blood seeps into her cloak, mingling with the forest's earthy scent.

Rogue Fall

Whisper, poised at the edge of the rooftop's precipice, maintains a firm hold on the rogue. Despite the rogue's cunning and agility, he struggles to free an arm to launch a counterattack with his dagger. Nevertheless, Whisper's sharp claws and expert grip keep him securely restrained. Beneath her, the store's chaos swirls, a symphony of survival and sorcery; each cry, each clash a note struck sharp in the chord of battle below. Her decision solidifies with the clarity of ice forming, abandoning subtlety for swiftness. With a sudden, fluid ferocity, she thrusts the entangled rogue from the roof, the figure plummeting and landing with a sickening thud upon the hard earth. The world contracts around her as she vaults down, feline grace reclaiming momentum in mid-air, her heart a steady drumbeat beneath her silken fur. She lands silently, flowing through the doorway like a stream of midnight water into the tempest of friend and foe, ready once more to thread her prowess into the weaving of combat's fierce tapestry. The thrown rogue, battered and broken, lies forgotten amidst the rubble.

Elara is startled by Whisper's sudden reappearance. Despite this, she remains focused on the building, her senses registering enough to grasp that her companions are in grave danger. She urgently calls out to Scarlet, telling her to dispel the fog cloud, which Scarlet promptly does. Without hesitation, Elara rushes to join her and Kragor inside. Whisper follows but pauses in the doorway, alert for threats inside or out.

Medic!

Surveying Scarlet and Kragor's injuries, she quickly assesses that Kragor's condition is more critical. She places her hands gently on the grievous puncture wound left by the crossbow bolt, her touch glowing with divine energy. The healing light rapidly closes the wound, restoring vitality to his mottled green-gray skin. Kragor, caught off guard yet deeply appreciative, meets Elara's kind gaze, and a silent bond is forged between the orc and the aasimar.

Final Blows

As Elara is tending to Kragor, Scarlet runs towards a nearby bandit that is just now orienting themselves after the fog dispersed. Eyes glowing with untamed magic, Scarlet calls upon nature's wrath. With a fierce, primal incantation, her fingertips elongate into razor-sharp claws, dripping with corrosive acid. In a swift motion, she lashes out, and her savage strike lands true. The bandit staggers back, pain etched across their face as the toxic claws rend through leather and flesh, leaving a searing wound. The druid's usually gentle demeanor is momentarily overshadowed by raw, feral power, as the bandit teeters on the brink of defeat, humbled by nature's unforgiving might.

Halite steps forward with a grim determination, his massive form casting a foreboding shadow over the bandit struggling to stay upright from Scarlet's fierce attack. With a swift and fluid motion defying his immense size, Halite shifts his weight back, then lunges forward with an uppercut trajectory. It pierces through the air with a whistling sound, meeting the bandit's chest in a visceral collision. The force of the jab lifts the bandit off his feet momentarily, his final gasp cut short by the weapon's deadly embrace. Life flickers out of his eyes, and the limp body slides down the trident's length. Halite grimaces, more out of reflex than malice, as he shakes the bandit free with a swift, practiced motion, the lifeless form dropping to the ground with a thud.

Now sufficiently recovered to rejoin the battle, Kragor focuses his attention on the bandit far across the room that he suspects of shooting him. Although he can't be sure of the bandit's guilt, he raises his war hammer toward his

target and shouts, "Te Exsecro!" The air shimmers with malevolent energy as a cold, dark aura coils around the bandit like an invisible serpent. Without hesitation, Kragor follows with another spell, yelling "Dolor," and unleashes a surge of eldritch energy from his war hammer that strikes the bandit square in the chest. The impact of the blast results in an ugly wound. Immediately, shadowy tendrils twist and curl over the shredded flesh causing it to blacken and crumble, leaving the bandit teetering on the brink of death.

Surrender

Halite, his towering form casting an imposing shadow across the cluttered interior of the ransacked antique shop, moved with purpose toward Kragor's target: a bandit whose bravado had been seared away by the crackling energy of the orc warlock's magic. The air still shimmered with the fading traces of arcane power, and the bandit, already on the brink of collapse, could only watch as the goliath fighter closed the distance between them like an inexorable force of nature.

The trident in Halite's grip gleamed with an unsettling menace, its barbed points promising a swift and painful end should it be called upon to deliver one. The bandit, a mere lithe elf in the presence of such formidable warriors, felt the weight of his own mortality for what seemed like the first time. His sword clattered to the wooden floor, a hollow sound that resonated through the shop, punctuating his surrender.

"I yield," the bandit croaked, his voice strained with fear and desperation. He raised his hands, palms open and empty, a universal sign of capitulation. His eyes darted to his remaining comrade, wide with silent urging.

The last standing bandit, who had watched the battle unfold with growing dread, knew the odds all too well. He had witnessed the fate of their fallen companions—three already dispatched with ruthless efficiency by the duo of Kragor and Halite. The decision was not a difficult one.

He dropped his own weapon, a well-worn crossbow, to the floor and raised his hands above his head in submission. "We don't want anymore trouble," he said, his voice carrying a tremor that matched the frantic beating of his heart.

Kragor surveyed the scene, his eyes, glowing faintly with residual magical energy, meeting Halite's. An unspoken understanding passed between them—this victory, as hard-fought as it was, did not need to claim further lives.

With the tension of combat beginning to ebb, the antique shop's air felt still, though the echoes of the skirmish lingered. Surrounded by overturned furniture and scattered relics of a bygone era, the bandits' surrender marked the end of the struggle, their lives spared by the mercy of those far mightier than they.

Whisper, having ensured the rogue she tossed from the roof was no longer a threat, finally entered the antique shop and closed the door behind her. As she did, the rogue moved to a crouched position around the corner, relieved that his theatrics had been successful. Intending to enter the building when the coast was truly clear, he remained vigilant, pressing his ear to the cool glass of the window to eavesdrop on the victorious adventurers.

Interrogation

Elara and Scarlet eyed the bandits with intensity, their curiosity piqued by the confession of surrender. "Who are you and what were you doing here?" Elara demanded, her voice steady yet demanding answers.

The first bandit, regaining a bit of composure but still visibly shaken, replied, "We were sent by Hulil, a priestess of Tiamat. She instructed us to search this place. Two months ago, there was a robbery here, and now Hulil's got this strange freezing sickness. She hoped we might find a clue here in the shop. But we found nothing."

Scarlet's gaze remained firm as she pressed

further, “Then why did you attack us?”

A hint of embarrassment colored the bandit’s cheeks. “We were spooked. We heard some weird noise, then you guys barged in. Especially that chick with a horn on her head,” he gestured toward Elara. “We panicked. We’re not used to dealing with people like you.”

In the meantime, the rogue outside, crouching below the window, absorbed the exchange, piecing together the dynamics at play.

Scarlet produced a weathered receipt with notations about Aeorian artifacts and presented it to the bandits. “Have you seen these items?”

“They’re with Hulil,” the bandit admitted reluctantly, his eyes on the documentation with evident recognition. “She’s at Croaker’s Cave,” confirming what the party had already learned from Hulil’s sister, Tulgi.

Satisfied with the information, Kragor dismissed the subdued bandits in no uncertain terms: “Leave everything and get out.” Seizing their chance, the bandits quickly discarded their weapons and coins before hurrying for the door, the rogue outside remaining concealed until the coast was truly clear.

Loot

After searching the bandits’ leavings and their late compatriots’ bodies, the party tallied the loot: 14 gold pieces, eight silver pieces, five crossbows, 30 bolts, five scimitars, and a dwarf-sized shirt blazoned with “Scanlan Shorthalt — The Meat Man Cometh”. (Elara judged this last item to be a rare find and might fetch as much as two gold pieces.)

The party then turned to the antique shop, assessing the chaos that engulfed it. The room was in disarray, bookshelves overturned and trinkets strewn about. Amidst the disorder, they stumbled upon a chilling sight—a frozen elf lying lifeless in bed. It was Verla Pelc, and the grim discovery confirmed that the place had not seen tidiness for weeks.

In a thorough inspection of both the shop and the dead bandits’ belongings, they discovered two bows and various odds and ends. Deciding a respite was in order, they planned to rest before heading to Croaker Cave.

Who is this guy?

Unbeknownst to the adventurers, the rogue remained vigilant, listening to their intentions and preparing to bide his time until they left.

Party Inventory

Currency

Count	Coin
14	gold pieces
8	silver pieces

Equipment

Count	Item
1	Æorian(?) Dagger
1	grappling hook
5	crossbows
30	bolts
5	scimitars
1	Shorthalt Concert Shirt

Aeorian(?) Dagger

Wondrous item, rare

A finely wrought dagger previously sold to Pelc's Curiosities, pilfered by Tulgi Lutan, and surrendered by same to Kragor Grimstride.

Shorthalt Concert Shirt

Wondrous item, rare

A dwarf-sized shirt blazoned with "Scanlan Shorthalt — The Meat Man Cometh".

Value: two gold pieces.

Appendix B — Dramatis Personae

1. **Bandits**: Guild members working for Hulil, they break into Pelc's Curiosities searching for clues about the curse and engage in combat with the adventurers before surrendering.
2. **Bill**: A Glassblade seated in the tavern, warning of the dangers associated with the curse impacting Urgon and Tulgi.
3. **Bortock**: A jovial dwarf who tends bar in the local tavern, interacting with the adventurers and providing them with refreshments and lodging information.
4. **Elara**: An inquisitive member of the party, likely with magical abilities, as she performs spells and aids Kragor with healing.
5. **Elro**: A weathered elf adorned with the insignia of a "Glassblade." He introduces himself to the adventurers at Urgon's funeral and seeks their help in determining the cause of the curse.
6. **Halite**: A towering goliath fighter, characterized by his immense size and strength. His weapon of choice is a massive trident, and he acts with determination and strategy during conflicts.
7. **Hulil Lutan**: Tulgi's sister, a priestess of Tiamat, and the mastermind behind the search for clues related to the freezing sickness. She has the remainder of stolen treasures at Croaker Cave.
8. **Jarl Stonebeard**: The weathered and taciturn captain of the longship *Frostwind* that brought the adventurers to Palebank Village. His demeanor is quiet, and he is experienced with sailing through icy waters.
9. **Kragor**: An orc warlock, wielding dark magic and an ethereal war hammer. He's strategically minded and capable of casting eldritch spells to protect his allies and subdue enemies.
10. **Rogue**: A thief initially grappled by Whisper on the roof. Though he seems defeated, he stealthily listens to the adventurers' plans, suggesting future intrigue.
11. **Scarlet**: A druid with access to nature magic, demonstrated by her ability to summon mist and turn her fingertips into toxic claws during combat.
12. **Tulgi Lutan**: A solitary trapper and one of the afflicted with the same symptoms as Urgon. She, along with her sister Hulil, were involved in stealing Aeorian treasures as part of a crime syndicate.
13. **Urgon**: A deceased dwarven adventurer who returned from Eiselcross with treasures and a chilling affliction. His demise is a centerpiece of the story, leading the adventurers to investigate the source of his mysterious curse.
14. **Verla Pelc**: The owner of Pelc's Curiosities, discovered frozen and lifeless in the shop by the adventurers, indicating the seriousness of the ongoing curse.
15. **Whisper**: A tabaxi with sharp senses and agility, capable of moving swiftly and silently, proving her skills when grappling with a rogue on the rooftop.